American Born Chinese

By Gene Luen Yan

(Scene: Danny's kitchen table)

MELANIE: Van der Waals forces of attraction are stronger when more of WHAT are present?

DANNY: Mmm . . .

MELANIE: Danny, you're drooling.

DANNY: What? Oh! Well, I – that happens when I'm really concentrating on your – I mean – CHEMISTRY.

MELANIE: Will you please stop fooling around? If we don't get this attraction stuff down by tomorrow --

DANNY: You know, Melanie, since we're on the topic of attraction, I've been meaning to talk to you about something…

MELANIE: *(blushing)* I've actually been hoping –

DANNY'S MOM: Danny!

DANNY: *(Sigh)* Hold that thought. Yeah, Ma?!

DANNY'S MOM: I have some exciting news! Guess who's coming to visit?

DANNY: Who?

DANNY'S MOM: Your cousin Chin-Kee!

DANNY: *(Danny drops textbook and looks terrified)*

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INTRODUCTION

Warning . . . . this selection contains extreme negative stereo-types of Asian Americans – but sometimes the best way to confront these stereotypes is through humor. In fact, according to the author, Gene Luen Yan, who IS an Asian American, approaching this stereo-type head-on may, in fact, begin to bring us closer together. In a recent interview he said: "I hope that a kid who has never felt part of the majority, a kid who has always felt like an outsider, will understand, regardless of what it is that makes them an outsider, that that is not an experience that's unique to them. Actually, more of us feel like outsiders than insiders"

So don't be afraid to laugh, but in the back of your mind, mull around the overly stereo-typed character of Chin-Kee. American Born Chinese by Gene Luen Yan

DANNY'S MOM: I knew you'd be excited! Your father went to go pick him up at the airport! He should be here any minute now!

MELANIE: Danny, who's cousin Chin-Kee?

CHIN-KEE: *(Chin-Kee barrels into room)* Harro Amellica! Cousin Da-Nee! Rong time no see! Chin-Kee happy as GINGER ROOT pranted in nutritious manure of WELL-BRED OX!

DANNY: *(whispers, in horror)* Hi Chin-Kee.

CHIN-KEE: *(Chin-Kee notices Melanie)* WHA--?! Confucious say, "Hubba-Hubba!" Such pletty Amellican girl wiff bountiful Amellican bosom! Must bind feet and bear Chin-Kee's children! *(Chin-Kee notices Danny's angry reaction)* Oh no! Chin-Kee so vely solly! Dis pletty Amellican girl wiff bountiful Amellican bosom must berongs to cousin Da-Nee! Perhaps Chin-Kee can find pletty Amellican girl for hisself when he attend Amellican school tomollow wiff cousin Da-Nee!

DANNY: Ma?!

DANNY'S MOM: Oh you two are going to have so much FUN together!

(Scene: Oliphant High School, the first period bell is already ringing)

CHIN-KEE: Why cousin Da-Nee bling Chin-Kee to school so rate? Other student already in crass!

DANNY: Just hurry up. And stay QUIET!

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CHIN-KEE: AH-SO! What big, bootiful Amellican school! Chin-Kee Rike! CHIN-KEE RIKE VELY MUCH!

(Scene: Government classroom)

TEACHER 1: Come on people! LOOK ALIVE! Didn't ANY of you do the assigned reading last night?! Let's try this one more time. The three branches of the American government are . . .

CHIN-KEE: OHH OHH! Chin-Kee know dis one!

DANNY: Put your hand DOWN!

TEACHER 1: Go ahead . . . Ah, Chin-Kee, was it?

CHIN-KEE: Judicial, executive and regisrative!

TEACHER 1: Good Chin-Kee! Very good! You know people – it would behoove you all to be a little more like Chin-Kee.

CHIN-KEE: See, cousin Da-nee? Chin-Kee tol' you! Chin-Kee know!

(Scene: History classroom)

TEACHER 2: The Nina, the Pinta and the –

CHIN-KEE: --Santa Malia!

(Scene: Science classroom)

TEACHER 3: The ulna is connected to the –

CHIN-KEE: --Humelus!

(Scene: Math classroom)

TEACHER 4: R squared is greater than six R—

CHIN-KEE: L is less than or equal to zero or L is greater than or equal to six.

(Scene: Spanish classroom)

TEACHER 5: En esta historia, el perro de jose es –

CHIN-KEE: --Branco y muy glande!

(Scene: Cafeteria)

CHIN-KEE: Would cousin Da-nee rike to tly Chin-Kee's Clispy flied cat gizzards wiff noodle?

DANNY: Leave me alone.

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STEVE: Dan the man!

DANNY: Steve!

STEVE: Hey, props on making the legendary Oliphant High Varsity basketball team, kid!

DANNY: Come on, now. We both knew it was inevitable.

STEVE: Well, being as how you're a transfer from Hughes Academy, I'd say it was anything BUT inevitable. What were you scrubs called again? The "water lilies?"

DANNY: Oh, PLEASE. I've got a jump-shot that'll make you cry like a little sissy girl.

STEVE: Ha, ha, we'll see about that at practice today, kid. So, ah…you hangin' with a new crowd?

DANNY: NO! This is my cousin Chin-Kee.

CHIN-KEE: Harro!

DANNY: He's just visiting.

STEVE: So how long you in town for, Chin-Kee…

DANNY: Hey, you… you happen to have an extra copy of the game schedule?

STEVE: Why? Gimme a sec… Ah! There you go. That'll be $100, plus a date with your fly girlfriend. Oh, wait… you don't have a fly girlfriend!

DANNY: Ha ha. Thanks, man.

STEVE: You gonna be at practice today?

DANNY: How else am I gonna make you cry like a little sissy girl?

STEVE: *(laughs)* See you then, kid.

DANNY: All right.

CHIN-KEE: Hee-hee-hee HA HA HA HA HA HA HA HA!

DANNY: What's your problem?!

CHIN-KEE: Me Chinese, me play joke! Me go pee-pee in his Coke!

STEVE: BLARF! What the heck's wrong with my Coke?!

(Scene: Cafeteria)

DANNY: Listen, Melanie, I'm sooo sorry about all that stuff my cousin said –

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MELANIE: No. I shouldn't have left in a huff like that last night. It wasn't your fault. I mean, in some ways, it's kind of flattering.

DANNY: So, does that mean you'd be up for catching a movie with me on Saturday?

MELANIE: …I actually wanted to talk to you about that, Danny. We're good friends, and I really LIKE being friends. I don't want to do anything to mess that up.

DANNY: I'm not like him, Melanie. I'm nothing like him! I don't even know how we're related!

MELANIE: Calm down, Danny! Geez! This isn't about that, okay? It's about us being friends, and me not wanting to jeopardize that!

DANNY: Whatever.

MELANIE: I'll see you around okay?

STEVE: Hate to tell you this kid, but practice ended twenty minutes ago.

DANNY: I know. I had detention.

STEVE: Too bad. You missed the three-pointer of the century – made by yours truly, of course. You all right, Danny?

DANNY: Can I tell you something, Steve?

STEVE: Sure, man. What's up?

DANNY: You know how I transferred from Hughes Academy at the beginning of the year? Well, the year before that I transferred from Rohmer High.

STEVE: How come?

DANNY: I'm only a junior and I've already been to three different schools. *(Sigh)* Every year around this time, I finally start getting the hang of things, you know? I've made some friends, gotten a handle on my schoolwork, even started talking to some of the ladies. I finally start coming into my own. Then he comes along for one of his visits.

STEVE: Who?

DANNY: Chin-Kee. My cousin. He's been visiting me once a year since the eighth grade. He comes for a week or two and follows me to school, talking his stupid talk and

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eating his stupid food. Embarrassing the crap out of me. By the time he leaves, no one thinks of me as Danny anymore. I'm Chin-Kee's cousin. It gets so bad by the end of the school year that I have to switch schools.

STEVE: Come on, kid. It ain't gonna go down like that here.

DANNY: How do you know?

STEVE: People here aren't like that. No one ever says anything about my weight. Well, maybe that's because I broke Todd Sharpnack's nose for calling me "Mr. Jiggles" when we were freshmen. But, whatever. People here are different. You'll see. Heck, if anyone ever gives you troubles, I'll break his nose.

DANNY: You're probably right. Thanks, Steve.

STEVE: Come on, kid. I'll buy you a Coke.

DANNY: A Coke? What, so I can pee in it?

STEVE: That's what happened to my Coke? He peed in it? BLAAAARGFFF!

(Scene: Library)

CHIN-KEE: *(Singing)* Talk to me, terr me yo' name! You brow me off rike it's all da same! You rit a fuse, I am ticking away rike a bomb! Yeah baby! She bang! She bang! Yeah baby! She move! She move! I go clazy! 'Cause she rook rike frower but she sting rike bee! Rike evely girl in histoly! She bang! She bang!... *(Sees Danny)* WHA? --?! Ah-so! Harro! Cousin Da-nee finarry come! Riblaly boling, so Chin-Kee entertain ferrow patlons wiff rivery song! Cousin Da-nee just in time for second set!

DANNY: I'm sick of you running my life, Chin-Kee! I want you to pack up and go back to where you came from!

CHIN-KEE: Ha! Ha! No, cousin Da-nee! Chin-Kee visit not over yet. Chin-Kee no reave until visit over!

DANNY: Go away!

CHIN-KEE: Chin-Kee stay.

DANNY: *(Smack)*

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CHIN-KEE: Cousin Da-nee, prease! No understand—

DANNY: *(Smack)*

CHIN-KEE: Prease! No more!

DANNY: *(Smack)*

CHIN-KEE: Cousin Da-Nee no risten, now must suffer unmitigated fully of spicy Szechuan Dragon! WA-TA! Sirry Cousin Da-nee. Chin-Kee ruv Amellica. Chin-Kee rive for Amellica. Chin-Kee come visit evely year. Forever. Forever!

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2011 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2018 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
NIETOC
IL State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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